Mijbil the Otter

A Tale of an Unbreakable Human-Animal Bond

Class 10 English First Flight | By Gavin Maxwell

Gemini Notebook

The Decision for an Otter

In the New Year of 1956, author Gavin Maxwell travelled to Southern Iraq. After his dog Jonnie died, he decided he wanted an otter as a pet.

He believed his Scottish home, Camusfearna, was an “eminently suitable spot” because it was ringed by water.

A friend advised him to get an otter from the Tigris marshes, where they were as common as mosquitoes and often tamed by the Arabs.

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The Arrival in Basra

Maxwell waited in Basra for delayed mail from Europe, enduring an agonizing five-day wait involving broken telephone lines and religious holidays.

Taking his mail to his bedroom, he found two Arabs squatting beside a squirming sack. They handed him a note: “Here is your otter...”

Opening that sack began Maxwell’s lifelong “thraldom to otters” (a strong, absolute fascination).

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Mijbil's Appearance & Identity

Medieval Dragon
Initially looked like a small, medievally-conceived dragon.

Mud Armour
Coated in symmetrical pointed scales of mud; took a month to clean off.

Velvet Fur
Beneath the mud, he had soft velvet fur like a chocolate-brown mole.

Maxwell's Otter
A race previously unknown to science. Zoologists christened it *Lutrogale perspicillata maxwelli*.

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Mijbil Discovers Water

For the first 24 hours, Mij was aloof and indifferent. By the second night, he slept peacefully in the crook of Maxwell's knees.

Taken to the bathroom, Mijbil went wild with joy—plunging, rolling, and splashing like a hippo.

The Otter Philosophy: Water must be kept on the move. When static, it is wasted and provoking,. Every drop must be spread about!

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Mijbil's Intelligence & Play

Turning Taps

Within two days, Mij escaped to the bathroom, fumbled at the taps with his paws, and turned on the full flow of water. He chittered with irritation if he turned it the wrong way.

Soccer Player

Shuffled a rubber ball around the room like a four-footed soccer player, dribbling and throwing it with a powerful flick of his neck.

Juggling Marbles

Mij's favorite pastime. He would lie on his wide, flat back and juggle two or more glass marbles up and down his belly without dropping them.

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Journey to England: The Box

Maxwell dreaded the prospect of transporting Mij. Because British airlines refused animals, he booked a flight to Paris, then London.

The airline insisted Mij be packed in an 18-inch square box. Maxwell left Mij inside to get accustomed, but returned to an appalling spectacle.

Mij had torn the inner lining to shreds, getting exhausted and blood-spattered. With only 10 minutes to the flight, a miserable Mij was forced back inside.

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The Flight Adventure

Maxwell sped to the airport like a [“ricochetting bullet.”] On board, he confided in the airhostess—calling her the [“very queen of her kind”]—and gave her fish to cool.

She suggested he keep Mij on his knee. But when the box opened, Mij was out in a flash!

Chaos erupted: Squawks, shrieks, and a woman screaming [“A rat!”] Maxwell dived for Mij, missed, and ended up with his face covered in curry.

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The Reunion on the Plane

The airhostess remained remarkably calm, promising to find the animal and bring it back to Maxwell's seat.

As Maxwell craned his neck trying to follow the hunt, he suddenly heard a distressed [chitter of recognition and welcome] at his feet.

Mijbil bounded onto Maxwell's knee and began to [nuzzle] his face and neck, cementing their deep bond of trust.

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Life in London: The Suitcase Game

Mijbil and Maxwell remained in London for a month. Mij played with ping-pong balls, rubber fruit, and a terrapin shell from his native marshes.

He invented a game that kept him [engrossed] for an hour at a time using a damaged suitcase with a sloped lid.

Mij would place a ping-pong ball on the high end, dash to the other end, [ambush] its arrival, grab it, and trot back to start again.

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Mijbil's Compulsive Habits on Walks

The Paving Blocks: Maxwell exercised Mij on a lead. Mij developed habits like schoolchildren, insisting on placing his feet squarely on the center of each paving block.

The Iron Railings: As they walked the London streets, Mij had an irresistible urge to touch every seventh upright of the iron railings.

The School Wall: On the way home, Mij would tug Maxwell to a low primary school wall, jump on it, and gallop its full 30-yard length, distracting everyone.

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Londoners' Reactions & Guesses

The Mustelline Family

Londoners didn't recognize an otter (part of the Mustelline family, like badgers and weasels). Maxwell faced a "barrage of conjectural questions".

The Wild Guesses

People guessed wildly: a baby seal, squirrel, walrus, beaver, bear cub, leopard, and even a "brontosaur".

The Highest Score

A labourer digging a hole put his hands on his hips, stared in surprise and affront, spat, glared, and growled: "Here, Mister — what is that supposed to be?"

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Super Revision: Story Timeline

Camusfearna

Maxwell's dog dies; decides to get an otter from the Tigris marshes.

Basra

Mail is delayed. Arabs arrive with a squirming sack containing Mijbil.

The Bathroom

Mij discovers water, splashing wildly, and learns to turn on the taps.

The Box

Mij destroys his travel box and gets injured; Maxwell rushes to the airport.

The Flight

Mij escapes on the the plane, causes chaos (curry incident), but returns to Maxwell.

London

Mij invents the suitcase game and develops compulsive street-walking habits.

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Board Vocabulary: Essential Keywords

NCERT Phrase	Simple Meaning
Thraldom	Being completely under the control or fascination of something.
Eminently suitable	Highly or perfectly appropriate for a purpose.
Apathy	Complete absence of interest or emotion; indifference.
Provoking	Causing anger, frustration, or a strong reaction.
Appalling spectacle	A highly shocking, dreadful, or horrific scene.
Ricochetting bullet	Moving incredibly fast and bouncing violently off surfaces.
Engrossed	Completely absorbed or deeply interested in an activity.

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Exam Booster: Themes & Character Traits

Character: Mijbil

- Highly intelligent (turning taps, inventing complex games), deeply affectionate (nuzzling Maxwell on the plane), energetic (water splashing), and full of unique, compulsive habits on the street.

Character: Gavin Maxwell

- Patient, deeply caring (distressed when Mij bleeds in the box), highly observant (notes Mij's exact anatomical and behavioral
behavioral details), and totally committed to pet ownership logistics.

Core Theme

The story highlights the intense, beautiful, and sometimes chaotic bond between humans and animals, emphasizing the deep responsibility and lifestyle changes required to care for a wild pet.

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